brunt of it being the senior officer. This didn't endear me to the CO either.

The next day, Maj Thyagarajan called me over to apologize. It was because of him that I had got into trouble, he said, adding that I should concentrate on my career and not be a 'lazy lout' like him with nothing much to look forward to. Of all the people who have advised me, I think I owe the most to Muthu. I had put in about three years of service by then, been promoted to Captain but had not really excelled anywhere. I had got a 'C' grade in the Young Officers' Course and was just coasting along with no real aim in mind, so it was indeed time to take stock. The next year, I appeared for the Part 'D' promotion exam, which is a mandatory requirement for promotion to Major. The examination has six papers, which can be passed in parts. It was not uncommon for officers to clear only one paper a year. It so happened that I cleared the Part 'D' exam, all six papers in one go, the first officer in Lucky Seven to achieve this feat in a long time. In fact, Veena was as incredulous as the others when I told her that I had passed in the first attempt. Later the same year, the team that I led came first in the Divisional Mine-Laying Competition, another first, as we hadn't had any podium finish in our three years at Bikaner. On the Imagery Interpretation Course for Officers (IICO), I qualified with an instructor 'I' grading. I realized that what Muthu had said was right. If I wished to, I could go places. Or perhaps, marriage had made me a better person.

Budhwal was a comparatively 'soft' field, where families could join for short durations. The officers' accommodation comprised two Tent Replacement Scheme (TRS) huts. These huts were constructed on a little mound about 50 to 60 metres away from the Officers' Mess along a small stone path slightly above ground level. The huts themselves were low-cost affairs,

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